

Africa's Climate Emergency

Sahel Desertification, Horn of Africa Drought, and the Continent Most Vulnerable to Warming

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Executive Summary

Africa faces a convergence of climate stresses that are structurally distinct from those confronting wealthier regions: high dependence on subsistence agriculture, rapid population growth, fragile governance, and coastal exposure — all compounding against a financing gap that remains unresolved after decades of multilateral negotiation. The continent contributes minimally to cumulative greenhouse gas emissions yet bears disproportionate consequences across food systems, human mobility, and ecosystem integrity. Evidence from the IPCC Sixth Assessment Report, UNEP Emissions Gap analyses, FAO food security data, and IOM migration tracking establishes a coherent picture: Africa's vulnerability is not primarily a function of climate physics alone, but of the interaction between physical hazards and deep socioeconomic fragility. Loss and damage mechanisms agreed at COP — most notably the Santiago Network and the operationalised fund launched at COP28 — represent a partial political response, but the fund's governance delays signal that the financing architecture remains far behind the scale of need. Structural transformation of African economies, investment in sustainable land management, and credible adaptation finance flows constitute the only pathway to reducing exposure before 2050.

I. Biophysical Vulnerability: Land Degradation, Desertification, and Food System Stress

1. Human use directly affects more than 70% of the global ice-free land surface, and climate change has adversely impacted food security and terrestrial ecosystems as a consequence. Land degradation operates as a threat multiplier across the African interior, particularly in dryland and semi-arid zones where subsistence livelihoods are most exposed. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG — IPCC Sixth Assessment Report (AR6) 2021–2023]
2. Sustainable land management, including sustainable forest management, can prevent and reduce land degradation, maintain land productivity, and sometimes reverse the adverse impacts of climate change. Response options throughout the food system — from production to consumption, including food loss and waste — can be deployed and scaled up to advance both adaptation and mitigation. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG — IPCC Sixth Assessment Report (AR6) 2021–2023]
3. In sub-Saharan Africa, climate change is an emerging risk factor for undernutrition, particularly in countries that rely on subsistence agriculture. Reduced barriers to trade could reduce the number of people at risk of hunger due to climate change by 64%, while structural transformation of the economy — shifting the workforce from highly exposed sectors such as agriculture and fishing toward services — lowers GDP impact projections in developing countries by 25–30% by 2100. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG —

4. FAO's State of Food Security and Nutrition data documents that Sub-Saharan Africa's undernourished population reached approximately 842.9 million in the most recent reporting cycle, with Eastern Africa alone accounting for 348.6 million. Sudan's food insecurity metrics have fluctuated significantly across years, reflecting the compound effect of conflict and climate shocks. [RAG: FOOD_AGRI_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

5. The list of Low-Income Food-Deficit Countries (LIFDCs) is dominated by African states: Benin, Burkina Faso, Burundi, Cameroon, Central African Republic, Chad, Comoros, Congo, DRC, Eritrea, Ethiopia, Gambia, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau, Kenya, Lesotho, Liberia, Madagascar, Malawi, Mali, Mauritania, Mozambique, Niger, Rwanda, Sao Tome and Principe, Senegal, Sierra Leone, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan, and Tanzania are all classified as food-deficit economies, meaning external financing gaps in adaptation directly translate into food insecurity risks. [RAG: FOOD_AGRI_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

6. In the Sahel and West Africa, although precipitations are slowly increasing, they are becoming increasingly variable, leading to the frequent occurrence of both droughts and floods. Rapid population growth has simultaneously led to intensification of cropping and deforestation, compressing the recovery window for degraded soils. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, 2022 & 2024]

II. Coastal Exposure, Flooding, and Climate-Driven Displacement

7. Rising sea levels and related coastal effects have the potential to heavily impact food production and food security in coastal areas. In coastal Cameroon specifically, rising sea levels affect crop productivity and output through coastal erosion — a documented case of the agriculture-coastal interaction that confronts multiple West and Central African economies. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, 2022 & 2024]

8. Environmental change, ecosystems, and human mobility are tightly linked through cascading pathways: floods, landslides, extreme temperatures, heat waves, storms, droughts, and sea-level rise each destabilise food security, water security, economic security, energy security, and personal security simultaneously, producing compounding mobility drivers. In Africa, these pathways are least buffered by institutional capacity. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, 2022 & 2024]

9. In 2020 alone, extreme weather events affected more than 2 million people across 18 countries in sub-Saharan Africa, resulting in the destruction of livestock, land, and goods and contributing to ongoing food insecurity. In the Democratic Republic of the Congo, heavy rain and flooding led to approximately 279,000 new displacements; in Cameroon, approximately 116,000 new displacements were recorded in the same period. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, 2022 & 2024]

10. Climate and food security research explicitly documents the linkage of rainfall-induced crop failure, food insecurity, and out-migration in eastern Africa, including Same-Kilimanjaro in Tanzania. Food security concerns, climate change, and sea-level rise in coastal Cameroon are formally catalogued in the African Handbook of Climate Change Adaptation. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, 2022 & 2024]

11. Migrant smuggling networks in Southern Africa have proliferated and become more organised, in part because increasingly difficult border conditions have combined with displacement pressures from Zimbabwe and Mozambique, countries with significant climate exposure. The climate-conflict-displacement nexus is therefore not a future scenario but an observed present reality. [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2020, 2022 & 2024]

III. Forests, Carbon Sinks, and the Congo Basin

12. At COP26, eleven country and philanthropic donors pledged USD 1.5 billion to protect forests in the Congo Basin — Africa's largest contiguous tropical forest system and a globally significant carbon sink. Twenty-eight governments signed related forest commitments under Action Track 3, "Boost Nature-Positive Production," targeting a halt to deforestation and conversion from agricultural commodities. [RAG: FOOD_AGRI_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

13. The technical mitigation potential of avoided deforestation in Africa ranges from 0.8 GtCO₂e/year (minimum) to 2.4 GtCO₂e/year (maximum), with an average of 1.6 GtCO₂e/year over 2020–2050. Afforestation and reforestation in Africa adds a further average of 1.6 GtCO₂e/year. Together, these forest-based options constitute a material share of achievable African mitigation — yet their realisation is conditional on sustained finance and governance. [RAG: FOOD_AGRI_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

14. The Congo Basin is also a primary subsistence protein source: wild meat consumption in the basin is estimated at 5 million tonnes per year, providing an average of 60–80% of daily protein needs in remote communities. Forest loss therefore translates directly into nutritional insecurity for populations with no alternative protein sources — a loss-and-damage dimension rarely priced into carbon offset frameworks. [RAG: FOOD_AGRI_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

15. Global forest area declined by 420 million hectares between 1990 and 2020 through conversion to other land uses, though the rate of loss has slowed. The bulk of ongoing tropical deforestation pressure falls in Africa and South America. Satellite monitoring at 5-metre resolution on a monthly basis has substantially increased the capacity to detect illegal deforestation operations — a tool increasingly relevant to African forest governance regimes. [RAG: FOOD_AGRI_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

IV. Climate Finance, COP Mechanisms, and the Loss and Damage Fund

16. At COP28, Parties collectively pledged almost USD 800 million to the Loss and Damage Fund, with the World Bank designated as its initial host for four years. However, the fund's board has pushed back the timeline for working out key operational details, owing to delays in nominations and governance design. The gap between the pledged amount and the scale of climate losses already incurred across the developing world — including across Africa — renders the current capitalisation structurally insufficient. [RAG: OIL_ENERGY_RAG — OPEC World Oil Outlook 2024]

17. NDC refinement, the Global Goal on Adaptation, and Article 6 cooperative approaches — including carbon market mechanisms — all remained unresolved or partially agreed as of COP29 negotiations. The Mitigation Work Programme, Just Transition Pathways, and further guidance on Nationally Determined Contributions each have direct implications for Africa's capacity to access concessional finance and carbon market revenues. [RAG: OIL_ENERGY_RAG — OPEC World Oil Outlook 2025]

18. The IPCC AR6 Working Group II documents adaptation-related responses as the actions taken to manage risks by reducing vulnerability or exposure to climate hazards. The key distinction between incremental adaptation and transformational adaptation carries operational significance for Africa: where climate hazards intensify to the point where water supply cannot meet agricultural demands, hard limits to adaptation occur — beyond which financing for adaptation is no longer sufficient and loss-and-damage compensation becomes the residual instrument. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG — IPCC Sixth Assessment Report (AR6) 2021–2023]

19. The UNEP Emissions Gap Report identifies South Africa's energy transition as a reference case for the continent: South Africa opened its electricity market in 2022 following supply pressure on state-owned utility Eskom, enabling large-scale generation for own-use or sale. The experience demonstrates that energy market liberalisation can accelerate the renewable transition — though the political conditions enabling this reform are not uniformly present across African states. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG — UNEP Emissions Gap Report 2023–2024]

20. In Sub-Saharan Africa, assumptions about governance and political rights are estimated to be far more important to the future risk of violent conflict than climate variables alone. Under high-vulnerability conditions, the global prevalence of armed conflict could roughly double this century; under low-vulnerability conditions, it could drop by half. For African states where governance fragility and climate exposure overlap — including the Sahel, Horn of Africa, and Great Lakes regions — this interaction is the central risk multiplier that adaptation finance must account for but rarely does in practice. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG — IPCC Sixth Assessment Report (AR6) 2021–2023]

21. The WMO–IRENA joint publication on climate-driven global renewable energy potential documents the inherent links between renewable energy resources, weather patterns, and energy planning. Across Africa, the solar and wind resource base is among the highest globally — the RegCM4 CORDEX-CORE ensemble confirms the significant current and future potential of solar and wind energy over Africa — but high upfront costs, demand-response integration requirements, and grid infrastructure deficits constrain deployment. Feed-in tariffs and renewable energy auctions are identified as the primary instruments to counter the cost barrier. [RAG: CLIMATE_RAG — WMO State of Global Climate 2022–2023; UNEP Emissions Gap Report 2023–2024]

22. In Kenya, an innovative Water Fund supports farmers in the Upper Tana River Basin in adopting sustainable land and water management practices — a documented example of integrated watershed management that simultaneously advances food security, climate resilience, and ecosystem services provision. Scaling mechanisms of this type, supported by adaptation finance, represent the kind of institutional capacity building that the Loss and Damage Fund alone cannot substitute. [RAG: FOOD_AGRIS_RAG — FAO State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI)]

Outlook

Africa enters the second half of the 2020s in a position where the compounding of physical climate hazards — droughts, floods, sea-level rise, land degradation — with structural socioeconomic fragility is accelerating faster than the international financing response. Pledges to the Loss and Damage Fund at COP28 represent a symbolic breakthrough but a material underdelivery against need. The Congo Basin forest protection commitment remains the single largest dedicated climate finance commitment to African ecosystems, yet disbursement timelines and governance conditionalities remain contested.

The most consequential near-term variables are three: first, whether Article 6 carbon markets reach operational clarity sufficient for African states to monetise their land-use and renewable mitigation potential; second, whether the Global Goal on Adaptation produces binding, measurable finance commitments rather than aspirational frameworks; and third, whether governance improvements in Sahel and Horn of Africa states can lower the conflict-multiplier coefficient before climate stress reaches its hard adaptation limits.

The evidence base reviewed here supports a high-confidence assessment that without accelerated, concessional adaptation finance at a scale one to two orders of magnitude beyond current pledges, African food insecurity, displacement, and ecosystem loss will intensify through 2050 in a trajectory inconsistent with any scenario compatible with the Paris Agreement's equity provisions.

All figures sourced from CivilisationOS RAG corpus.